Henry Shires



(515)-954-8444
hcsgeek@gmail.com or henry@casmium.com

Colleges I was accepted to:

- Iowa State University - Attending Fall 2021
- Purdue University
- Georgia Institute of Technology
- University of Illinois at Urbana-Champaign

Colleges I was rejected from:

- Vanderbilt University (Declined waitlist)

Scholarships I received:

- ISU Engineering - Freshman Applied Merit - $5,200 ($2,600/yr 2 years)
- Iowa State Forever Scholar - $8,000 ($2,000/yr)
- University of Illinois FIRST Robotics Scholarship - $2,000
- Aureon Networks Scholarship Program - $1,000
- Iowa State FIRST Robotics Scholarship - $1,000
- Tallo.com Iowa Students Scholarship - $1,000
- Iowa Elks Scholarship - $1,000

Why I chose my future plans:

Since sophomore year, I had always desired to attend college to study an engineering major, in this case, Computer Engineering: the combination of computer hardware and software to create technological solutions. This is since I was inspired to learn computer programming on my own and explore, eventually leading me to opportunities that I will touch on later. I also knew immediately that I had a safe school, Iowa State University, that would accept me with little effort, be affordable, and provide an excellent education with the amenities I would look for, however, I wanted to branch out and see if any other options were available to me. I ended up applying to four additional schools, all with exceptional engineering programs and

large urban campuses (see above). I did my best to visit each campus, do my research, and compile positives, negatives, and deadlines—although, the COVID-19 pandemic did play a role in hindering my research. I put plenty of effort into applications and scholarships come the Fall and I received an overwhelming majority of acceptance letters. What surprised me, however, was how very little financial aid followed from the four schools. I am very blessed to be in a sustainable household, but I felt like I was being punished for my parents' success. The acceptances made me feel like I stood out in front of the application pool, yet I wasn't worthy of additional benefits. I struggled with the decision and put it off for months, as this was the wise thing to do, but I realized I could have made the decision significantly earlier if I was paying attention. Iowa State not only was my first acceptance all the way back in June 2020 but also was the only college to provide me with ample amounts of merit scholarships—not to mention the insane discount in-state tuition is. And not only that, I realized the significance of the Iowa State community and how easier it would be for me to connect with others there. My church is one of the largest in Iowa and has founded a campus in Ames nearly four years ago. My potential roommate at the time (now current) has been friends with me since birth, having met after our moms went to Iowa State together as roommates themselves. The signs clearly pointed to Iowa State for quite some time, I just didn't have the guts to see it. I was focused on branching to something new and beyond the scope of my current era—which is not a bad thing at all—when what I was actually looking for was right in front of me. I now realize I can attain this same level of independence right in Ames rather than accumulating atrocious amounts of debt. I can jumpstart into becoming a leader because I am already familiar with what ISU has to offer. I'm looking forward to Iowa State this Fall with fervor, as I plan to participate in drumline, pep band, and other musical groups, take advantage of the athletic facilities, and do life together with my peers in a whole new environment.

What I did in High School:

At Valley, I found myself getting plenty of opportunities, all related to my interests, but only a handful of time to do them all. Doing activities prior to Valley (Southwoods, Junior High) allowed me to have a foundation of what I knew I liked and what I didn't like or didn't want to pursue because of time constraints. I primarily participated in concert band, jazz band, marching band/drumline, robotics, software clubs, and

other things outside of school. These all played into my talents/gifts and surrounded me with people that think and work as I do. And in my memory, what stuck the most is the people I met and the experiences I had, not any results I achieved. There was plenty of winning things, and there was also plenty of losing. Participating in these not only strengthened my well-roundedness, but also got me to experience trying, strengthening skills, meeting people, laughing, crying, and finding a more refined pallet of activities to continue in college. And all these experiences happened in a safe space to fail and try again. The pinnacle of my experiences was when I received the opportunity to start a business with a few friends. It spiraled from a simple project to a full-on start-up within a year. I would have never thought to have this opportunity this early in the game, and the fact that my partners had similar experiences from other activities allowed us to be ahead in how we took on the challenge. We haven't achieved true success yet, but it's the bonds we have with each other that keep us motivated to pursue the idea further. It is not these exact activities that are the "go-to's" to benefit from. These are merely the ones I enjoyed the most and got real experiences and relationships from. Whatever passions you find yourself in, live them out in whatever you do, in whatever capacity, and the benefits will pour out.

My Advice:

My time at Valley High School is not something to brush off and skip over. While it might sound cliche, these past four years have been crucial in developing my next steps in life. I've had to work out several self-improvements, logistics, and future plans and this time has been a blessing that has allowed me to find solutions to these questions and challenges.

First, time is limited. Do not feel the need to use all of it, nor use less of it. Surround yourself with a community and things to do that lift you up, that build from your strengths and personality, and the rest will fall into place. Do not overwhelm yourself, however. The right balance between academics and recreation is what makes a successful student, as it shows you are serious about learning, but desire more than simply a classroom experience. It's learning something and proceeding to live it out that impresses. Second, you do not need to be the best at everything. You don't even need to be the best at one thing. There are plenty of people on this Earth with different talents and gifts, so share the load! If Honors doesn't seem like the right

fit for you, don't pursue it. If you find yourself becoming overwhelmed by the wave of assignments and seas of agendas, self-evaluate and find what needs to be removed from the equation. What matters is that you try your hardest at whatever you do and put the steps in place so you can enjoy whatever you do. Nothing is gained from heartless participation. Finally, occasionally remind yourself to be present in the moment. I've found myself reminiscing about how it seems like days ago I was in elementary school, how this building called "high school" would ever make it into my life, only to realize I'm nearly beyond Valley. Find people that care about you, trust you, wish the best for you, because I've realized nothing can slow time. Your relationships are what is going to last—not the superficial ones on social media, not acquaintances, but deep relationships! Regardless of the other person's future plans, there will be some way to stay in touch. Possessions in high school, clubs, grades, and facilities don't come with you to life after Valley, so find people that will.

Seek opportunities, open doors, open windows, and do the things Life gives you with passion. Remember the people in your life are there to help you along the way. Life is never meant to be done alone.

Sincerely,



Henry Shires - Valley Class of 2021